On the other hand, a national crisis can also unite the nation. Vajpayee won a national election in 1999 after the Kargil War. The BJP's security narrative was always predicated on staring down Pakistan. With the surgical military strikes of September 2016 and the Balakot airstrikes of February 2019, it had the security narrative firmly under control. China's concerted border intrusions upset that balance. By June 2020, Modi had met Xi Jinping eighteen times since coming to power in 2014. He had visited China five times, the most by any Indian prime minister.[60] External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar has argued that the higher engagement was because India 'counts for more and is more active' and that Modi's foreign engagements with Japan, Europe and the US would also yield higher results than before.[61] Even so, for a leader who had invested so much in the China relationship, the charge of being misled by China, just as Nehru was in 1962, is a risk. However, by aggressively publicising the deployment of previously covert battalions like the Special Frontier Force, consisting of Tibetan refugees, on the LAC,[62] and through strategic border appearances with the troops by Prime Minister Modi, who delivered messages of strength dressed in camouflage gear, the political narrative largely remained under control for the BJP until the close of 2021. It seemed that India was settling down for the long haul. A previous stand-off at Sumdorong Chu with China in 1986 had only ended nine years later, as Jaishankar pointed out to *The Hindu* journalist Suhasini Haider.[63]

And yet, the longer the military stand-off, the more it will bleed India economically. Even more so, if the friction expands beyond the Ladakh–Leh sector to other sectors along the LAC, which is 4,065 kilometres long, extending right up to Arunachal Pradesh. The Ladakh deployment entailed a great deal of emergency-buying of equipment for the Army's frontline troops. Any extension of such deployments would entail much higher defence spends. In short, an expansionist China looking to tie up India could do so by forcing expenditures that Beijing (with an annual GDP that is almost five times larger than India's and 2.2 per cent of annual GDP spending on defence) has deeper pockets for than New Delhi (2.35 per cent of GDP spending on defence).[64]